former Chairman was marked by repeated departures from the culture and ethos of the group' and poor performance.

It also stated that only after his removal did Mistry make the allegations about 'business decisions' that he was 'party to for over a decade in different capacities'. He was also on the boards of Tata Motors and Tata Steel, which he alleged had suffered because of Ratan's decisions.

The holding company also took exception to the leaking of Mistry's letter, saying, 'It is a matter of deep regret that a communication marked confidential to Tata Sons board members has been made public in an unseemly and undignified manner.' The statement added: 'It is unforgivable that Mr Mistry has attempted to besmirch the image of the Group in the eyes of the employees.' The embittered relations between Tata Sons and Mistry had reached their nadir.

When Mistry launched the attack against Ratan, he was still the chairman and director of the group's major entities, including IHCL, Tata Motors, Tata Power, Tata Steel, TCS, Tata Global Beverages, Tata Chemicals, Tata Industries and Tata Teleservices. Now, the prospects of Mistry's continued association with these companies became untenable. The subsequent board meetings and the specifically requisitioned EGMs of these companies bore witness to continual face-offs between Mistry's and Ratan's supporters.

The Companies Decide

IHCL was the first company to hold a board meeting after Mistry's replacement as chairman, Tata Sons, on 4 November. During this meeting, the issue of Mistry continuing as the company's chairman came up for some animated discussion. The IHCL board comprised ten members of whom six were independent directors. Unusually, before the board meeting, the independent directors met separately at 2 p.m. at Bombay House. It was an 'unprecedented decision', 'apparently orchestrated by [Deepak] Parekh [an independent director on the board]', wrote *The Telegraph* from London. The meeting drafted a statement that was a wholesome endorsement of Mistry's performance and expressed 'full confidence' in his leadership of the company.

After this meeting, the board met, with Mistry in the chair. The three-hour meeting saw a clear divide between the six independent directors and the chairman on one side and the nominee directors on the other. The